

August 2026

Dear Howard,

I've been working in Lafayette long enough to know Reliez Valley well, and a property like 15 Surmont Ct stands out immediately - a 0.73-acre court lot with Mount Diablo views, an in-law suite, a pool, a sports court, and open-beam ceilings that most buyers have to travel out of state to find. When I saw the listing come off the market after 62 days without a sale, I wanted to reach out, because that outcome doesn't match what this home actually is.

What the listing history tells me is that the strategy ran out of runway before the right buyers were found. At \$514 per square foot, this home was priced well below the Lafayette range for a property with this footprint, setting, and amenity stack - which means the conversation wasn't about the price at all. It was about reach and narrative. The Mount Diablo view from that wrap-around deck, the in-law suite with its own separate living areas, the sports court, the three fireplaces - those are specific details that a certain kind of buyer is actively looking for. A standard listing approach often treats features like those as a bullet-point list rather than the center of the story.

I've put together a short analysis of where I think the friction was, along with how I'd approach a relaunch differently - what the pricing position actually signals, which buyer profiles this home is built for, and what a full-coverage campaign would look like to reach them. It's in the pages behind this letter.

If you're already working with an agent toward a new listing, please feel free to set this aside - no hard feelings. If you're not, I'd welcome a short conversation whenever you're ready.

With respect,



Ben Olsen

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The Path to Sold:

15 Surmont Ct

Lafayette, CA 94549

5.0 Beds · 4 Baths · 3,498 Sq Ft · Lafayette

The Blueprint for a Successful Sale

Prepared For: The Owners of 15 Surmont Ct

Presented By: Ben Olsen · BrightWork Realty Advocates

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

A Rare Reliez Valley Estate with Views, Versatility, and Three Levels of Living - and a Listing That Left Most of That on the Table

15 Surmont Ct is a genuinely uncommon property in the Lafayette inventory. Positioned at the end of a private court on nearly three-quarters of an acre, it offers sweeping Mount Diablo views, a pool with sundeck, a lighted sports court, three fireplaces, and a fully self-contained in-law or au pair suite on the lower level - all within ten minutes of downtown Lafayette and BART. The open-beam ceilings in the main living room, the Shoji screens, the six-burner Dacor range, and the wrap-around deck create a home that reads as a lifestyle property, not just a square-footage play. Buyers in this price range who are looking for that combination - private lot, views, multi-generational flexibility, and outdoor amenities - have very few options in Lafayette. This home checks every one of those boxes.

The listing ran 62 days and came off the market without a sale. That gap between the home's actual asset base and the outcome it produced points to a strategy problem, not a property problem. At \$514 per square foot, the home was priced at the low end of the Lafayette range for a fixer-tier property - and this is not a fixer. The marketing didn't resolve that disconnect. A buyer comparing this home against other Lafayette listings at this price point needed to understand, specifically and visually, what justified the number and what the number actually represented relative to the market. That case was never fully made.

\$1,798,000

List Price

\$514/sqft

Price Per Sq. Ft.

None

HOA Fees

A relaunch needs to do one thing well: make the Mount Diablo views, the multi-level flexibility, and the private court setting feel real to buyers who are researching online from San Francisco and the East Bay before they ever schedule a showing. That starts with the visual package and the narrative, and it ends with active distribution to the buyers who are already looking for exactly this.

MARKET FORENSICS: WHY IT DIDN'T SELL

Every expired listing has a story. Here's what the listing history tells us about what held this one back, and what a different strategy would have done.

Friction #1: Stale Listing Psychology After 62 Days

Once a listing crosses the 45-day mark, buyer behavior shifts in a specific and measurable way. Buyers stop evaluating the home on its merits and start asking why it hasn't sold. After 62 days on market, that question had become louder than the Mount Diablo views, the pool, or the in-law suite. The stigma wasn't earned - it was created by a strategy that didn't actively find the right buyers before the clock ran out. The buyers for a property like this don't browse passively on Zillow; they need to be reached where they're actually looking, and reached before they've already made a decision about another home.

* THE BRIGHTWORK DIFFERENCE

BrightWork runs geo-targeted digital campaigns into San Francisco and the East Bay, reaching buyers who are actively researching Lafayette relocations before they've identified a specific property - so the right audience finds this home before the market clock becomes the story.

Friction #2: The View and the Setting Were Never Shown

A home with sweeping Mount Diablo views from a wrap-around deck, a private 0.73-acre court lot, and a pool and sports court below is a property that lives or dies on its photography and aerial context. Standard MLS angles - front elevation and interior room shots - leave the lot position, the hillside setting, and the panoramic view invisible to online buyers. A buyer researching from San Francisco or Oakland cannot tell from a flat exterior photo that this home sits at the end of a private court with an open-sky view to the east. That visual gap is why qualified buyers scroll past without booking a showing.

* THE BRIGHTWORK DIFFERENCE

BrightWork's Sky Tour gives buyers the aerial context that ground photography cannot - lot position, court setting, hillside backdrop, and the relationship between the home and the view it commands - before they ever step inside.

Friction #3: A Complex, Multi-Level Home With No Digital Walk-Through

A three-level home with two family rooms, a self-contained lower-level in-law suite, a primary suite with private deck, and distinct indoor-outdoor flow on the main level is genuinely difficult to convey through a photo gallery. Buyers comparing multiple properties at this price point need to understand the layout and the flow before they commit to a 30-minute drive to Reliez Valley. Without a way to walk the home digitally, busy professionals and out-of-area buyers default to simpler, easier-to-understand listings - not because this home is harder to love, but because it's harder to picture. That friction cost this listing real showings.

* THE BRIGHTWORK DIFFERENCE

A 3D Matterport tour lets buyers walk every level of this home from anywhere - including the lower-level suite and the primary deck - so the layout is understood and the home is already familiar before they schedule a showing.

POSITIONING ANALYSIS

Metric	15 Surmont Ct	Lafayette Market Context
Price per Sq. Ft.	\$514/sqft	\$650–\$720/sqft (fixer range) \$780–\$840/sqft (renovated)
Lot / Setting	0.73 acres, private court, Mount Diablo views	Typical Lafayette lot: 0.15–0.35 acres, standard street
Architectural Character	Open-beam ceilings, Shoji screens, three-level layout, 3 fireplaces	Standard ranch or split-level, conventional interior finishes
Premium Features	Pool, lighted sports court, wrap-around deck, in-law suite, EV charger, Dacor range	Typical: 2-car garage, standard kitchen, no secondary suite
HOA	None	None to \$200/mo depending on community

The verdict: At \$514/sqft versus a benchmark range of \$650-\$720/sqft, this home sits near the lower end of that range. At \$514 per square foot, 15 Surmont Ct was listed well below the low end of the Lafayette fixer range - and this home is not a fixer. The lot, the views, the in-law suite, the pool, and the outdoor amenity package place it solidly in renovated or premium territory, where comparable Lafayette properties trade between \$780 and \$920 per square foot. That pricing position was a real advantage, but only if buyers understood what they were getting at that number. The strategy needed to build that case clearly and deliver it to the right audience - and that's exactly where the opportunity remains.

THE RELAUNCH STRATEGY: 3 PILLARS

We don't re-list this home. We relaunch it with new media, a narrative that finally does it justice, and distribution designed for the buyer it deserves.

Pillar I - Reach the Buyers Who Are Already Looking for This

The buyers for a Mount Diablo view home with a private court lot, pool, and in-law suite are not browsing randomly - they know what they want, and they're researching Lafayette from San Francisco and the East Bay before they make a move. BrightWork's geo-targeted digital campaigns put this home directly in front of that audience, in the channels where they're actually spending time, before they've committed to something else. Passive MLS distribution wasn't enough for this property. Active distribution is.

Pillar II - Build the Visual Package This Home Deserves

A 0.73-acre hillside court lot with panoramic views and a multi-level layout is one of the harder properties to represent in a standard photo set - and one of the most important to get right. The relaunch starts with a Sky Tour to establish the setting and the views from the air, a 3D Matterport walk-through so buyers can move through all three levels digitally, and cinematic interior photography that gives the open-beam ceilings and the wrap-around deck the presence they carry in person. More informed buyers means fewer wasted showings and stronger offers.

Pillar III - Price Position Needs a Narrative, Not Just a Number

At \$514 per square foot against a Lafayette market that runs from \$650 to over \$900 for comparable-quality homes, this listing had a compelling value story to tell - and it never told it. A buyer who sees the number without the context either questions what's wrong or moves on. BrightWork's listing strategy pairs the pricing data with a direct, specific explanation of what the buyer is getting relative to the market - so the number feels like an opportunity, not a question mark. That's the conversation that turns interest into showings.

A DIFFERENT OPTION: THE QUIET LISTING

Sell Without the Disruption

A traditional listing puts a sign in your yard, opens your door to strangers every weekend, and puts your home's history on public record. For a home that already went through one listing cycle, there's a better starting point.

BrightWork maintains an active private buyer list through our off-market platform. These are Bay Area buyers who've opted in specifically to receive property alerts before anything hits Zillow. They're motivated, pre-qualified, and they believe an off-market home represents a real opportunity, which means they engage seriously.

- * **No public days on market.** The prior listing history stays private. A new buyer sees none of it.
- * **No sign, no open houses, no disruption.** The sale is a private conversation between a motivated buyer and a motivated seller.
- * **Option to go public anytime.** If the right off-market offer doesn't materialize in an agreed window, we transition directly into a full relaunch strategy with no time lost.

* HOW IT WORKS

We alert our private buyer list through offmarket.brightworkrealty.com - Bay Area buyers specifically seeking properties before they go public. If a serious match emerges within the agreed window, we negotiate and close privately. If not, we launch the full relaunch strategy immediately, with clean momentum and no days-on-market exposure.

TIMELINE: THE BRIGHTWORK SMART WAY

Phase 1 - Pre-Market Preparation (Weeks 1–2)

Staging, full media production, and a Coming Soon campaign - or a quiet listing launch to our private buyer network, depending on your preference.

Phase 2 - Strategic Launch (Week 3)

Thursday launch on Zillow Showcase with the full media package in premium placement. Targeted SF/Oakland digital ads go live the same day.

Phase 3 - Momentum Management (Weeks 4–5)

Active follow-up on every save, inquiry, and open house visitor. Final Offer gives serious buyers a transparent channel to submit competitive offers.

Phase 4 - The Close (Weeks 6–7)

We engineer competition, not just field offers. Our process keeps both sides of the transaction moving cleanly toward a close.

WHY BRIGHTWORK REALTY ADVOCATES

- * **Deep local roots:** 45+ years in Moraga, Lafayette, and Orinda. Ground-level knowledge of what buyers in each community are actually paying for.
- * **Premium marketing as a baseline:** Cinematic photography, floor plans, 3D tours, and Sky Tours on every listing. Not a luxury add-on.
- * **Portal dominance:** Zillow Showcase and homes.com premium placement. More views, enhanced listing pages, all leads to your team.
- * **Modern offer tools:** Final Offer gives buyers a transparent path to engage and gives you real-time demand data in one place.
- * **True advocacy:** We don't re-list homes. We forensically review what went wrong and rebuild the strategy from the ground up.

This home has real assets that the market never got to properly evaluate. That's a correctable problem. The window to correct it is still open.

Ready to talk? brightworkrealty.com · (925) 255-9727

Scan to see what a relaunch looks like for your home: relaunch.brightworkrealty.com

Important Notice

If you have entered into a listing agreement or active representation agreement with a licensed real estate agent in connection with this property, please disregard this mailing.

BrightWork Realty Advocates is a licensed real estate team operated by Ben Olsen, REALTOR, California DRE License #01409268. This communication is not intended to solicit properties currently listed for sale or under active representation.

The market analysis and strategic observations contained in this report are based on publicly available listing data and BrightWork's professional assessment of market conditions. They are not a formal appraisal and should not be relied upon as a certified valuation.

All property data referenced in this report was obtained from public records and MLS history. BrightWork Realty Advocates makes no warranty as to the accuracy of third-party data sources.

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THE BRIGHTWORK ADVANTAGE

- Buy Before You Sell
- BrightFlip Pre-Sale Improvements
- Final Offer Platform
- Zillow Showcase + homes.com Premium
- Off-Market Network
- Built to Close Clean

YOUR LISTING ADVISOR

Ben Olsen

Founding Partner | REALTOR · BrightWork Realty Advocates · DRE# 02014153

Ben founded BrightWork on a specific premise: the best outcomes are built before a home ever lists. With twenty years serving the East Bay's most competitive submarkets, he's developed a clear point of view on what separates a sale that closes well from one that doesn't, and the preparation, marketing, and negotiation strategy to act on it.

He entered the workforce at 14 in construction, a background that shapes how he thinks about pre-sale decisions, disclosure strategy, and what buyers actually scrutinize at inspection. That's a different lens than most agents carry into a listing consultation.

His approach to marketing is built on the same logic. Every campaign is designed for your home's specific buyer, not the average buyer. Portal strategy, campaign integration, and buyer targeting aren't add-ons at BrightWork. They're the baseline. Pre-sale prep, real fixes, and full disclosure before the home lists. The preparation is the negotiation.

20+

YEARS SERVING
LAMORINDA

\$1B+

PROPERTIES
SOLD

1,000+

BUYERS &
SELLERS

WHY HE SENT YOU THIS PACKET

When a listing expires, Ben reviews it. Not to pitch you, but because after enough of them, the pattern of what goes wrong becomes clear. If you received this analysis, he looked at your specific property and has a specific point of view about what happened. That's the conversation he's offering. No listing agreement on the table. Just a review. He'll also walk you through programs that turn seller constraints into options, and show you what a transaction designed to get everyone to the closing table feeling good actually looks like.

Why BrightWork Realty Advocates

Rooted in Lamorinda since 1977. BrightWork is built on the premise that the best outcomes start before a home ever lists. An orchestrated campaign designed for your home's buyer, not the average buyer. Programs that turn seller constraints into options. Transactions designed so everyone gets to the closing table feeling good.

That's The Smart Way to Real Estate.

EIGHT REASONS SMART SELLERS CHOOSE BRIGHTWORK

01 Superior Presentation

Professional photography, floor plans, 3D tours, and Sky Tours on every listing. Not the luxury package. The baseline.

02 Premium Portal Presence

Zillow Showcase and premium homes.com membership. Higher view counts, better placement, and buyer inquiries that route to your listing team.

03 Integrated Campaigns

Every sign, mailer, and open house connects to a digital system. Curious neighbors become trackable leads.

04 Modern Offer Management

Real-time portal data guides pricing decisions. Final Offer platform for properties with strong multi-offer potential.

05 Financial Tools & Capital Programs

Capital to fund pre-sale improvements with no out-of-pocket cost until close. Plus programs that remove the timing trap entirely.

06 Off-Market Strategy

A private list of serious Bay Area buyers. Test demand quietly or gain early access before properties hit MLS.

07 Advocacy for Unsold Homes

When a home hasn't sold, we don't re-list at a lower price. We conduct a forensic review and relaunch with a rebuilt strategy.

08 Built to Close Clean

Pre-sale prep, real fixes, and full disclosure to every buyer before the house lists. He structures listings to attract the best first offers from a position no one can argue with. The preparation is the negotiation.

BrightWork has served Lamorinda since 1977. Over \$1 billion in local real estate sold.

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Not Every Home Needs a Public Launch.

For sellers who need privacy, flexibility, or a different kind of timing — BrightWork has a smarter first step.

Most agents know one approach: list on the MLS, hit the portals, hold open houses. That works for many homes. For sellers who need privacy, flexibility, or more control over timing, BrightWork offers a structured, documented private path to the right buyer — built on relationships in Lamorinda that go back to 1977.

OFF MARKET SELLING HAS ITS BENEFITS

Your Home, Your Timing, No Pressure

No days-on-market counter. No public record. No nosy neighbors. Your home stays entirely private until you choose otherwise, and if you do go public later, you start fresh, with a clean slate and zero wasted days behind you.

Buyers Who Are Actually Ready

BrightWork maintains a curated list of serious, pre-qualified Bay Area buyers who have asked to be notified about Lamorinda properties. They are not browsing Zillow. Every showing is by appointment, with someone who qualifies and is genuinely interested.

Real Feedback Before You Commit

An off-market phase gives you genuine buyer response before you decide whether to close privately or step into a full MLS campaign. Either way, you move forward with real data and momentum, not day-one guesswork.

BrightWork's network of private buyers and collaborative realtor relationships has served Lamorinda since 1977.

Over \$1 billion in local real estate sold.

Deep relationships in Moraga, Lafayette, and Orinda.

WHO THE PRIVATE PATH SERVES

The Privacy-First Seller

No public listings, no open houses, and no days-on-market counter visible to buyers and agents, for whatever reason, professional or personal.

The Seller Still Preparing

Test genuine demand while staging or repairs are still underway, without burning days on market before you are ready.

The Strategically Timed Seller

Your next move depends on how this one closes. Control the sequence rather than react to a public countdown clock.

The Seller Testing the Waters

Get real buyer feedback before committing to a full public launch — or decide you do not need one at all.

Your home. Your timeline. Your terms.

Ready to find out whether the private path is the right first step?

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